

STAGE TWELVE • LEADERSHIP

FIRSTS

FAQ

Anticipated participant questions and suggested facilitator responses

A Citrus Edition Facilitator Resource • Companion to the FIRSTS Manual

BY AYOMIDE AYENI

FIRSTS • FAQ

Stage Twelve • Leadership

PURPOSE

These are the questions that come up most often across cohorts of Stage Twelve, with a suggested facilitator response for each. Use these as a starting point, not a rigid script.

Frequently Asked Questions

Q1. What if I've never held a formal leadership title?

A: That's completely fine, and genuinely common in this stage. Real leadership material comes from informally organizing a group, influencing an outcome without authority, or simply observing what good and bad leaders around you actually did — none of that requires a title.

Q2. What if my honest answer to the leadership style assessment doesn't match how I see myself?

A: That gap is useful information, not a failure of the exercise. Bring it into the discussion — it might reveal a genuine blind spot, or the assessment may have caught an atypical moment. Either way, it's worth exploring.

Q3. How do I give constructive feedback without sounding harsh?

A: Lead with a genuine strength, be specific about the improvement area, and frame it around the person's own growth rather than just correction. Softening it too much, though, can bury the actual point — the goal is honest and kind, not vague and comfortable.

Q4. What if I don't currently have a real difficult decision or conflict to reference?

A: Use one you've observed someone else navigate, analyzed from the outside, or reach back to a past experience even if it's not currently active. The reflection skill transfers regardless of how recent the example is.

Q5. Is it normal to feel nervous about asking for honest feedback on my own leadership?

A: Yes, genuinely common. Most people have never done this deliberately. The discomfort doesn't mean you're doing something wrong — it usually means the exercise is working.

Q6. What if my leadership philosophy feels premature since I haven't led much yet?

A: Write what genuinely feels true based on your real experience so far, even if that experience is limited. It's meant to be a living document — you'll likely revise it significantly after a few more years of real leadership.